



AALBORG UNIVERSITY
DENMARK

Aalborg University Action Plan in the context of the CoARA Agreement

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The action plan was completed in April 2024, however concrete work with reforming research assessment with CoARA inspiration has been initiated in 2022 at Aalborg University.

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Timeline

- Strategic Counsel for Research and Innovation (SRFI) at Aalborg University (AAU) decided to develop and implement a new research indicator at AAU to replace the old national Bibliometric research indicator that ceased to exist per December 3rd, 2022.
- Sep-Dec 2022 the AAU Research Indicator developed by a cross-faculty team as well as representatives from administrative units including finances, innovation and the university library. Additionally, an external consultant was part of the working group.
- March 28th, 2023, AAU's signature to CoARA was accepted and validated.
- March 28th, 2023, AAU became a CoARA member.
- Fall 2022 – Spring 2023: Presentation- and hearing-processes in the academic counsels and AAU's main committee for cooperation (HSU)
- June 2023, the AAU Research Indicator was accepted by the university board.
- Aug-Dec 2023, implementation of AAU Research Indicator: Education, harvest, and performance agreements
- November 24th, 2023, AAU held a symposium on research evaluation in a CoARA perspective.
- February 2024 – first year with the AAU Research Indicator passed.

The Aalborg University Research Indicator

September 2022 to December 2022 [a CoARA inspired research indicator](#) was developed for internal use at Aalborg University. In the Spring of 2023, the indicator was presented to the academic councils as well as management boards at the university. Simultaneously, Aalborg University signed the Agreement for Reform of Research Assessment in the Spring of 2023. In this process, Aalborg University also became a member of CoARA as a sign of a commitment to be part of the change of reforming research assessment. In the Fall of 2023, the indicator was implemented at the university.

The indicator is designed for resource allocation at department level. The indicator consists of two parts. Part A is a more traditional quantitative and bibliometric part. However, in line with ARRA part A includes more publication types than the previous national indicator to accommodate for the diversity in research outputs. As an example, part A gives points to preprints, and editorials in addition to the more traditional research outputs such as articles and books. Part B adheres to an open science agenda and focuses on dissemination of knowledge and research more broadly by focusing on collaboration, visibility, and openness for instance through qualitative indicators.

The bibliometric part A is subject neutral and will be used across the university. Contrary, the Open Science part B is made separately at each department. Part B is evaluated based on a "performance agreement" where the department makes strategic decisions on how they will work with and improve in the areas of collaboration, visibility, and openness (areas inspired by the CoARA Agreement).

Starting Point

The AAU Research Indicator is developed with an Open Science mindset and with the intention to be shared and used by others who might find it relevant for assessing research using both bibliometrics and open science indicators in research evaluation. It is thus possible to adopt the indicator to other university context, adjusting to local needs and relevant indicators. For this purpose all material produced in connection with creating the indicator such as reports etc. are open access and under a creative commons licence 4.0: <https://vbn.aau.dk/en/projects/konstruktion-af-forskningsindikator-til-aau>

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Strategy and change approach

- *What guiding principles do you (and your community) think are priorities in your approach to reform?*

Transparency and inclusion should be leading principles in our work with a new research indicator at AAU. We have communicated progress and decisions throughout the work with developing the AAU Research Indicator. Academic counsels have been heard and comments therefrom included in the work.

- *How does your organisation intend to make the reforms to meet the guiding principles?*

To ensure that the organization adheres to the principles of transparency and inclusion, the organization will continue monitoring of the indicator and ensure inclusion of researcher perspectives via support and formally through annual meetings in the Academic Councils.

- *What is the process by which your organisation will work on the reform?*

The AAU Research Indicator is dynamic and will be reviewed and developed over time according to comments and recommendations from researchers and management at AAU. Comments to and experiences to AAU Research Indicator will be gathered and included in further development of the indicator decided by the SRFI.

Other areas than specific research evaluations at department level should be affected by the commitments of the CoARA Agreement. An open invitation to academic and administrative staff at AAU to take part in the reform work will be issued spring 2024. This will hopefully lead to consensus on a more detailed action plan on how to implement the commitments at AAU over the next five years.

Involvement of institutional community in the change process

- *How are you planning to involve relevant actor groups (such as researchers at different career stages, research support staff, administrators, and others, depending on the scope of your organisation)?*

When developing the AAU Research Indicator, representatives from each faculty were involved. For the more general CoARA startup meeting and further reform work at AAU we will involve all parties interested in research evaluation.

- *How will you share good practices (internally and with others)?*

Internally:

In Spring 2024, discussions around a Danish national chapter were initiated. at AAU, we are planning an internal meeting to start more initiatives on reform of research evaluation at the university. For the internal meeting, HR, Finance, “the innovation-department”, and deanship advisers are invited.

To ensure that the indicator and the changes to how AAU approaches research evaluation are communicated to different levels of the organization, internal courses on the AAU Research Indicator for researchers were held in the Fall of 2023, in the Spring of 2024 and again in the Fall of 2024. In addition, several departments and faculties have requested presentations over the past year.

Externally:

September 2023, The AAU Research Indicator was presented in Leiden at STI conference. Moreover, the indicator has been presented at several national and Nordic conferences.

November 2023, Aalborg University hosted a symposium in Copenhagen with the theme of research evaluation in a CoARA perspective. 120 persons from Denmark and the other Nordic countries attended the symposium. Science Europe, Danish and Nordic universities and research organisations and Danish funders were represented.

March 2024 a webinar planned by the Danish Association of Research Managers and Administrators is taking place. Representatives from all Danish universities (incl. AAU) will give their status on work and commitment to the CoARA Agreement.

Key challenges to address

- *Have you identified the Identify key challenges/gaps/bottlenecks/barriers in your organisation with regards to reforming research assessment and the adherence to the action plan? For which does your institution have the power/authority/resources to address?*

The transformation to include more formative indicators in especially the strategic performance agreements has proved to be challenging. It became clear that often summative indicators were chosen by the departments because they were used to benchmarking and thus were more comfortable with these indicators to begin with. Hence, this will be one of the areas where work is needed overall for the organisation to ensure that we succeed in changing the culture of research assessment to include a more formative approach to research assessment.

Operational action plan for a 5-year time frame

Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research

- *How does your organisation plan to enable recognition of more diverse contributions to research?*

In part A of the AAU Research Indicator, we have added more publication types in order to merit research outputs more broadly and thus recognize the diversity of research outputs across disciplines and fields. As a few examples, the AAU Research Indicator gives publication points to preprint, anthologies, editorials, and encyclopedia articles in addition to the more traditional research outputs.

Part B of the indicator goes a step further in the recognition of research contributions. Based on ideas of open science, each department selects outputs, which are important to the unique profile of the department. This means that each department must choose and explain in a performance agreement how they want to be evaluated based on the following three CoARA inspired headlines: “collaboration”, “visibility” and “openness”. An example could be the number of open access articles, or describing important external collaborations with for instance municipalities, where the research produced at the department contributes to new knowledge and changes in policies.

- *How does your organisation plan to enable greater diversity in career paths and profiles?*

Part B of the indicator encourage departments to render visible contributions by more profiles than just researchers. Collaboration with students, technical administrative staff, companies, hospitals etc. can be considered and be planned for at department level. Moreover, over the coming years, initiatives to engage with HR in terms of making the recruitment processes more aligned with ARRA will be initiated.

Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators

- *How does your organisation plan to accommodate qualitative evaluation mechanisms and base the use of metrics in a way that is aligned with your organisation’s value system?*

Part B of the indicator consists of a narrative description on which goals the department has set to achieved under the headlines of collaboration, visibility, and openness. The intention is to aid a framework for constructive discussions at faculty and department level around open science agendas – especially in the areas of collaboration, visibility, and openness.

Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index

- *How does your organisation plan to mitigate reliance on JIF and h-index?*

In the AAU Research Indicator prestige and ranking of publication channels is not considered when evaluating research output. Publication counts are weighted with citations, but not publication venue.

The indicator cannot be evaluated at individual level, and we already see a focus shifting away from individual performance to discussions around how to work with scholarly communication in an open science perspective. Moreover, the indicator does not provide a single bibliometric performance number for each department – it is a range of metrics and statistics.

Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment

- *How does your organisation plan to mitigate reliance on organisation rankings?*

There is a ranking-team at AAU, and it continues to exist. However, focus will not be on using rankings for research assessment at the university. Ranking results will be used in communication strategies when communicating externally about the university's educational and research profile.

Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to

- *Which resources will your institution allocate to the implementation of the research assessment reform? (Whether in terms of capacity or budget, to actively engage in the reform Journey)*

The Strategic Council for Research and Innovation at Aalborg University is the initiator of the research indicator, while the CRIS team at the university is responsible for its administration and development.

Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools, and processes

- *Does your organisation plan to pilot or implement alternative/new assessment criteria, tools, and processes (e.g. narrative CV format, competency-based CV format, evidence-based CV format, diversification of research careers and associated career progression)?*

The Aalborg University research indicator was developed and implemented in 2022-2023. In January 2024, the first assessment and review of the indicator was made by the Strategic Council for Research and Innovation at Aalborg University. One of the key points from the first year with the indicator is that the organisation must adjust and learn to approach research evaluation from a formative as well as summative perspective, and that these evaluations can/should include narrative as well as quantitative metrics and indicators. Especially the transformation to including more qualitative indicators takes time and is more complex but is also rewarding in terms of being able to demonstrate diversity between the departments and research fields. As an example, one department will be working with the narrative CV format to understand its possibilities and limitations.

Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use

- *Does your institution plan to provide training, guidance and support to assessment panels, committees, and juries?*

AAU already provides guidance at faculty and department level. We have courses and seminars targeted at PhD students as well as more senior researchers.

Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition

- *How does your organisation plan to exchange practices and foster exchange of good practices in national and international contexts?*

The previously mentioned symposium on reforming research assessment in November 2023 hosted by AAU served as a welcoming opportunity to engage with other research institutions and funding agencies in Denmark. Moreover, representatives from some of the other Nordic countries also took part in the symposium and there is continued positive correspondence both nationally, but also regionally in the Nordic

countries to continue the collaboration and work on reforming research assessment by learning from each other's practices.

Internationally, AAU will follow working groups, national chapters, and discussions in CoARA.

Communicate progress made on adherence to the principles and implementation of the Commitments

- *How will your organisation ensure the transparent communication of the organisation's research evaluation processes within and outside of the organisation?*

Though continued meetings with SRFI, the Academic councils, other administrative units as well as communication with individual researchers through courses and lectures, the ways in which AAU will use, monitor, and potentially adjust the indicator will be discussed and presented in these forums ensuring transparency and inclusion within the organization.

Outside of the organization, AAU will initiate a national chapter in Denmark. We suggest that open communication around institutional evaluation processes are a fundamental part the agenda for the Danish national chapter.

Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research

- *How does your institution plan to monitor and (re)evaluate its assessment criteria, tools, and processes? What will be the frequency? Who will be involved in the evaluation?*

The AAU Research Indicator is dynamic and will be reviewed and developed once a year according to comments and recommendations from researchers and management at AAU.

Part of the AAU Research Indicator is a performance agreement at department level made between the department and the faculty. The idea is that the department should take a stance on how they want to work with collaboration, visibility, and openness. The performance agreement is made once a year and statistics is provided to back up further decisions and ideas on how the departments for instance can work with increasing or selecting collaborations, on how to work with diverse groups for researchers (internally or externally), or on how to research visible in more fora and open to a broader audience.